

WHEN JORDAN OVERFLOWS

*** DENOTES POWER POINT SLIDE**

**** DENOTES INSTRUCTIONS TO
TECHNICIAN**

TEXT: Joshua 3:1-4, 8, 11-15 (NKJV) *“Then Joshua rose early in the morning; and they set out from Acacia Grove and came to the Jordan, he and all the children of Israel, and lodged there before they crossed over. ²So it was, after three days, that the officers went through the camp; ³and they commanded the people, saying, “When you see the ark of the covenant of the LORD your God, and the priests, the Levites, bearing it, then you shall set out from your place and go after it. ⁴“Yet there shall be a space between you and it, about two thousand cubits by measure. Do not come near it, that you may know the way by which you must go, for you have not passed this way before.” ⁸“You shall command the priests who bear the ark of the covenant, saying, ‘When you have come to the edge of the water of the Jordan, you shall stand in the Jordan.’” ¹¹“Behold, the ark of the covenant of the Lord of all the earth is crossing over before you into the Jordan. ¹²“Now therefore, take for yourselves twelve men from the tribes of Israel, one man from every tribe. ¹³“And it shall come to pass, as soon as the soles of the feet of*

the priests who bear the ark of the LORD, the Lord of all the earth, shall rest in the waters of the Jordan, that the waters of the Jordan shall be cut off, the waters that come down from upstream, and they shall stand as a heap.”¹⁴ So it was, when the people set out from their camp to cross over the Jordan, with the priests bearing the ark of the covenant before the people,¹⁵ and as those who bore the ark came to the Jordan, and the feet of the priests who bore the ark dipped in the edge of the water (for the Jordan overflows all its banks during the whole time of harvest)”

[Jeremiah 12:5](#) (NKJV) *“If thou hast run with the footmen, and they have wearied thee, then how canst thou contend with horses? and if in the land of peace, wherein thou trustedst, they wearied thee, then how wilt thou do in the swelling of Jordan?”*

INTRO: When a child is conceived in its mother’s womb, it lives in a sack of water for nine months; when a person is born into the Kingdom of God one of the first things they are commanded to do is to be baptized in water. (Jesus to Nicodemus – *“**Except you are born of water and of the Spirit...**”*)

There are three things a person cannot live without; food, air, and water!

For some reason, when I need some rest and relaxation I seem to be able to unwind better when I am near

water. (The ocean, a river, or a lake) Several times in Scripture, when Jesus needed some time alone he went to a lake or to the sea.

Rivers and bodies of water are some of the most beautiful scenery on earth. **(LEAVE ON SCREEN, UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** I can recall as a child, standing on the shoreline of the Pacific Ocean and both watching and hearing the waves beat against the rocky shoreline. One of the churches Susan and I pastored was near one of the most beautiful lakes on the earth.

Water speaks not only of beauty, but also of romance and intrigue. I gave my wife her engagement ring while sitting by a lake. As a young preacher, many times I would sit by a stream and meditate and pray.

Though rivers and bodies of water possess these qualities, they can also be a place of great danger. This is what our text is speaking of.

I. THE SETTING OF THE SCRIPTURE

Notice the events here at the Jordan River. Moses has died and Joshua is the new leader of the Israelites. Though he has been the right hand man to Moses, he is an unproven leader, because he has spent more than forty years taking orders and doing what he is told.

The Israelites are at the end of their wilderness wandering and they are about to reach a place of being offered another opportunity to occupy Canaan. Before the Israelites can occupy the Promised Land they must: **(PLACE ON SCREEN, ONE AT A TIME)**

- Cross Jordan (While it is at flood stage)
- Defeat Jericho (A fortified city)
- Defeat Ai
- Conquer Canaan (Occupied by giants)

This does not sound too difficult as long as you are reading a story, but it is far more difficult to live out in real life. Listen to the instructions of Joshua to Israel. Joshua 3:1-3 (NKJV) ***“Then Joshua rose early in the morning; and they set out from Acacia Grove and came to the Jordan, he and all the children of Israel, and lodged there before they crossed over. ²So it was, after three days, that the officers went through the camp; ³and they commanded the people, saying, “When you see the ark of the covenant of the LORD your God, and the priests, the Levites, bearing it, then you shall set out from your place and go after it.”***

The role of the people would be to follow the leadership of the Priests who were in charge of the Ark of the Covenant.

The instructions to the Priests were a bit more complicated. [Joshua 3:8](#) (NKJV) ***“The priests who bear the Ark of the Covenant, shall ‘come to the edge of the water of the Jordan, and shall stand still in the Jordan.”***

The Priests were to actually step into the Jordan. Remember, at this point the Jordan is a river at flood-stage! [Joshua 3:13](#) (NKJV) ***“And it shall come to pass, as soon as the soles of the feet of the priests who bear the ark of the LORD, the Lord of all the earth, shall rest in the waters of the Jordan, that the waters of the Jordan shall be cut off, the waters that come down from upstream, and they shall stand as a heap.”***

Jordan was overflowing its banks. This overflowing happened every spring due to the melting of the snow on the mountains of Lebanon to the North. [To the Israelites the Jordan was an obstacle to a long awaited promise, to the inhabitants of Jericho it was a first line of defense against a dangerous enemy! \(LEAVE ON SCREEN, UNTIL NEXT SLIDE\)](#) The inhabitants of Jericho hoped a flooding Jordan River would keep the Israelites away.

Did God not know that at this particular time of the year, Jordan would be at flood-stage? Of course God knew! He is all knowing! Plus the fact, this happened every year at about the same time.

II. FACING THE DIFFICULTY

A river at flood-stage is not an easy thing to deal with.
(My experience with the Red River – Hurricane Ike)

(PICTURES OF HURRICANE IKE
OVERFLOWING THE SEAWALL – OTHER
PICTURES OF OVERFLOWING RIVERS)

God does not place difficulties in our lives but when they come He provides the grace and power to deal with them! Jordan experiences are a normal part of life! It may seem to be the case, but difficult times are not unique to your situation, everyone has them!

There have been times:

- I visited the hospital and should have been a patient...
- I have counseled people when I needed counseling...
- I have given business advice when I could not get my hands around my own affairs...

Because we are reading an historical account we know the “*Rest of the story,*” *Jordan would divide; there would be a path three miles wide; the Children of Israel would walk across 5,000 abreast; (LEAVE ON SCREEN, UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)* this sounds easy

enough after the fact, but can you imagine how difficult a thing like that would be to believe for?

The significant fact here was the river would divide providing the Children of Israel with a path to victory, but this would not occur until the feet of the priests were in the overflowing river! Stepping in a river at flood stage is either the most idiotic thing one could do or it is an incredible act of faith!

As in this case, most of the time it seems that the Lord waits until the last possible minute to intervene in our situation! This is not unusual and it is not disingenuous on His part, it is His allowance for the development of faith in the person He is mentoring! Someone said, *“God never comes too late with too little, He is always right on time with more than enough!”* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN, UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

Jordan overflowing its banks suggests everything being out of control; insurmountable difficulty; no help in sight, but we must remember the words of the psalmist, Psalm 121:1-8 (NKJV) ***“I will lift up my eyes to the hills—From whence comes my help? ² My help comes from the LORD, Who made heaven and earth. ³ He will not allow your foot to be moved; He who keeps you will not slumber. ⁴ Behold, He who keeps Israel Shall neither slumber nor sleep. ⁵ The LORD is your keeper; The LORD is your shade at your right hand. ⁶***

The sun shall not strike you by day, Nor the moon by night. ⁷ The LORD shall preserve you from all evil; He shall preserve your soul. ⁸ The LORD shall preserve your going out and your coming in From this time forth, and even forevermore.

Notice: They were about to go in and possess the Promised Land when Jordan overflowed! There are those who have witnessed Jordan overflowing its banks in their lives; they have been there when the situation seemed to get down to the last minute; when they've gone their limit! Someone said, "*The darkest hour is just before the dawn!*"

Let us look at some people in the Bible who had a Jordan experience: **(PLACE ON SCREEN, ONE AT A TIME)**

- **The Three Hebrew Children** - Daniel 3:16 (NKJV) "*O Nebuchadnezzar, we have no need to answer you in this matter. ¹⁷ If that is the case, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and He will deliver us from your hand, O king. ¹⁸ But if not, let it be known to you, O king, that we do not serve your gods, nor will we worship the gold image which you have set up.*"

Special note: If we rightly interpret this Scripture, the three Hebrew Children are not giving God an out, they are saying "*If you do not throw us in the fire!*"

- **Daniel** - Daniel was thrown into a den of hungry lions! Daniel 6:19-22 (NKJV)
“Then the king arose very early in the morning and went in haste to the den of lions. ²⁰And when he came to the den, he cried out with a lamenting voice to Daniel. The king spoke, saying to Daniel, “Daniel, servant of the living God, has your God, whom you serve continually, been able to deliver you from the lions?” ²¹Then Daniel said to the king, “O king, live forever! ²²“My God sent His angel and shut the lions’ mouths, so that they have not hurt me, because I was found innocent before Him; and also, O king, I have done no wrong before you.” Notice, Daniel did not say, “You dipstick, what were you thinking!” He said, “Sir, we have a miracle here!”
- **Lazarus, Mary and Martha** – John 11
 (Martha went to meet Jesus but the Scripture say’s ***“Mary stayed in the house.”*** In verse 21 Martha responds to Jesus in the following way, ***“If you had been here my brother would not have died! But even now I know that whatever you ask the Father, He will do it.”***

Will troubles come? Sure! Will God stand ready to deliver us? You’d better believe it! He is NEVER too late – He NEVER shows up with too little – He is

ALWAYS on time, with MORE than enough, but sometimes we must first put our feet in the overflowing river before it will divide. (Illustrate this)

Jordan has overflowed in my life from time to time:

- When Jason was born...
- When we were fired from a church...
- When I was double crossed by some business partners...
- When Bro. Bates started his church...

I have a word for everyone who is in a Jordan experience today, [Psalms 30:5](#) (NKJV)

***“Weeping may endure for a night,
But joy comes in the morning.”***

III. PROBLEMS ARE MORE PREVELANT DURING HARVEST TIME

Notice when Jordan was out of control, during harvest time! [Joshua 3:15](#) (NKJV) ***“Jordan overflows all its banks during the whole time of harvest.”*** (Gideon – Judges 6:11-16 He was hiding to thrash wheat but the Angel called him ***“A mighty man of valor!”***)

[When we are in the time of harvest, difficulty; problems; trials; and troubles seem more frequent and severe. \(LEAVE ON SCREEN, UNTIL NEXT SLIDE\)](#) That’s because they

are, it is not an illusion! The enemy must make a last ditch effort to bring us down before we lay our hands on the promise! Isaiah 59:19 (NKJV) ***“When the enemy comes in like a flood, The Spirit of the LORD will lift up a standard against him.”***

We must always remember, the difficulties we face do not necessarily happen because one is out of the will of God—but rather, because we’re human and this is the time of the harvest!

(LEAVE ON SCREEN, UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) The question one must ask is the same question Jeremiah asked in his day, Jeremiah 12:5 (NKJV) ***“If thou hast run with the footmen, and they have wearied thee, then how canst thou contend with horses? and if in the land of peace, wherein thou trustedst, they wearied thee, then how wilt thou do in the swelling of Jordan?”***

How are we going to do in the day of great difficulty? 1 John 4:4 (NKJV) ***“Ye are of God, little children, and have overcome them: because greater is he that is in you, than he that is in the world.”***

1 Corinthians 10:3-5 (NKJV) ***“Though we walk in the flesh, we do not war according to the flesh. ⁴For the weapons of our warfare are not carnal but mighty in God for pulling down strongholds, ⁵casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself***

against the knowledge of God, bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Christ.”

Romans 8:35-39 (NKJV) *“Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword? ³⁶As it is written: “For Your sake we are killed all day long; We are accounted as sheep for the slaughter.” ³⁷Yet in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us. ³⁸For I am persuaded that neither death nor life, nor angels nor principalities nor powers, nor things present nor things to come, ³⁹nor height nor depth, nor any other created thing, shall be able to separate us from the love of God which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.”*

They went in and possessed the land.

Acts 20:24 (NKJV) *“But none of these things move me; nor do I count my life dear to myself, so that I may finish my race with joy, and the ministry which I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God.”*

The Israelites dealt with the difficulty, crossed Jordan and inherited the Promised Land! By the help and grace of God, we will not do less! **When difficulties arise, we will rise to the occasion! (LEAVE ON SCREEN, UNTIL END OF SERVICE)**

CONCLUSION:

Following harvest is a time of rest! For the Saints, the rapture follows harvest.

1 Thessalonians 4:16-18 (NKJV) ***“For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. ¹⁷Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord. ¹⁸Therefore comfort one another with these words.”***

1 Corinthians 15:51- 54 (NKJV) ***“Behold, I tell you a mystery: We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed— ⁵²in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. ⁵³For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. ⁵⁴So when this corruptible has put on incorruption, and this mortal has put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written: “Death is swallowed up in victory.”***

Revelation 20:1-3 (NKJV) ***“Then I saw an angel coming down from heaven, having the key to the bottomless pit and a great chain in his hand. ²He laid hold of the dragon, that serpent of old, who is the Devil and Satan, and bound him for a thousand years; ³and he cast him into the bottomless pit, and shut him up, and set a seal on him, so that he should deceive the nations no more till the thousand years***

were finished. But after these things he must be released for a little while.”